The Sword

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/35453365.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Eventual Adora/Catra (She-Ra) - Relationship

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Horde Lords AU, Canon Divergence, Canon Universe, angst with an eventual happy ending, Hurt/Comfort, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting, season one, Child soldiers with PTSD? It’s more likely than you think

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English

Series:
Part 1 of Give Up The Throne - Princess of the Horde AU

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Summary

Adora is convinced that she saw a sword when she fell from her and Catra's skiff in the Whispering Woods. That night, she sneaks out of the Fright Zone to investigate - only in this reality, Shadow Weaver catches her, and she is *interested* in Adora's talk of a glowing sword.
(Horde Lords Catradora AU – Canon divergent from episode one)

Part I

Chapter Notes

> Picking up right at episode one here. If it's been awhile: Adora gets promoted to Force Captain, she and Catra sneak off in the skiff and find the sword, they return to the Fright Zone, but the sword keeps calling to Adora, so she sneaks back out that night to investigate.
> Two small changes and everything is different: Neither Shadow Weaver nor Catra sleeps through the night after Adora sneaks out to return to the Whispering Woods.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Adora."

One word halts Adora in her tracks, a shiver running through her body. Shadow Weaver's tone always sounds a bit accusatory, but she couldn't have caught Adora at a worse time. She already has the stolen skiff keys in her hands and the yard where the skiffs are kept is just down the hallway. In hindsight, she doesn't know what she expected Catra to do to cover for her. She wasn't thinking straight. Why else would she bolt out of the bunk room to chase down a feeling from a dream? Adora turns around slowly, trying not to look too guilty. Her superior officer narrows her eyes at her from where she looms down the hallway.

"Shadow Weaver," Adora acknowledges, carefully fisting her hand around the key in her hand. She just has to hope that Shadow Weaver hasn't seen it yet and that she can get away with an insomnia excuse. It isn't wholly uncommon amongst the cadets. They are supposed to stay in their bunks after hours regardless of if they sleep, but pretty much no one follows that order, at least not every night. Adora is pretty good about staying in the bunk room herself, but Catra is usually willing to get up and whisper with her when it happens, so she at least has entertainment there.

“Where do you think you’re going?” Shadow Weaver asks, drawing her words out slow. It just gives Adora’s nerves more time to build. She swallows. From her tone, it sounds like Shadow Weaver already knows, but there is no way that she could predict Adora’s destination unless she somehow found out about their earlier trip to the Whispering Woods. Adora wracks her brain for a lie that is believable. She is bad at coming up with them on the spot.

“I just… had a weird dream. I needed air,” Adora tells her, straightening up a little and trying not to look guilty. That is at least the truth. It leaves out what she was going to do about that dream, but she can’t even use her supposed head injury as an excuse because she would have to explain how she got it. Really, she thinks the fall must be to blame for why she is sneaking around after hours. Her head doesn’t feel off, but she hallucinated a sword and is now running away to go follow a mystery voice from her dreams. That isn’t normal behavior.

“A dream that required you to steal a skiff key for the *second* time today?” Shadow Weaver asks. Adora jolts a little, meeting Shadow Weaver’s eyes – well, eye slits – to find them narrowed. Adora swallows, tightening her fist around the key. There is no way that Shadow Weaver knew about her taking the key before they left. She would have stopped them if she did. If she discovered it missing, however, it makes sense that she would watch the room closely for the rest of the day.

And now she has found Adora holding the key. Shadow Weaver is the Horde’s primary strategist. She can put two and two together. Denying it would be useless at this point, but Adora needs to make sure that Catra doesn’t get in trouble for this. The whole trip was Adora’s idea, and if Shadow Weaver finds out that she and Catra snuck out together, Catra will get in a lot of trouble. There is no way that Shadow Weaver would let her come to the siege on Thaymor then.

“I just wanted to celebrate the promotion and get some practice in with a skiff before the raid tomorrow, sir,” Adora tells her, tacking the honorific onto the end as if the afterthought will save

her hide. Shadow Weaver is impassive, but she doesn't seem very convinced, leaning forward to loom over Adora.

"Do not lie to me, Adora. I expect better from my Force Captains. Why are you sneaking out in the middle of the night?" Shadow Weaver demands. The words send a shiver down Adora's spine. She doesn't want to disappoint Shadow Weaver when she just got promoted – she especially doesn't want to be *demoted* – but even now, standing before her superior officer, Adora still feels the strange pull on the back of her mind. It is like the woods are calling to her.

She can almost hear the whisper of the mysterious woman's voice in the back of her mind. She knows, logically, that it shouldn't be possible. She knows that she should come to her senses and go back to bed. She especially knows that she shouldn't admit anything about her excursion earlier and risk getting both herself and Catra in trouble, but she can still see the sword in her mind and its glow tempts her to reach out and grab it. She blames that for why she opens her mouth and the truth comes out.

"I don't know. When I was out earlier, I thought I saw a sword, and now I'm having these weird dreams and I just… feel like I have to find it," Adora admits, her shoulders falling as she looks down. She is ashamed. She knows she has to sound crazy. Maybe Shadow Weaver is willing to write this off as a small breakdown in the middle of the night and ignore it. She really hopes that she doesn't pull her off the lineup for the Thaymor invasion. She can handle battle, she just can't handle mysterious women calling to her in her sleep.

"A sword?" Shadow Weaver questions, and to Adora's shock, her tone has picked up. Actually, that makes sense. A sword might be useful against the rebels. Maybe Adora can sell this as a tactical move. She looks up, finding Shadow Weavers hair and robe oddly still – well, oddly for her, most people don't have the magic to dramatically billow their hair all the time – like every part of her is trying to be silent and listen. Adora's heart thuds oddly in her

chest. She can't tell if it is anxiety or hope. Maybe Shadow Weaver knows something about it?

"It had a blue gem in the hilt. When I tried to touch it, the gem flashed bright and then it was gone. I've been having… visions ever since," Adora admits. To her shock, she hears Shadow Weaver draw in a small breath beneath her mask. Adora's heartrate instantly skyrockets. She said something that was enough to concern *Shadow Weaver*. She has messed up.

"I mean, it's probably just a head injury. I fell off the skiff. I should just go to the infirmary instead," Adora tells her, pointing her thumb over her shoulder and already taking a half step back as she desperately hopes that Shadow Weaver will fall for it. She doesn't. Instead, she shakes her head and then considers Adora for a long moment. Eventually, she starts forward, sweeping past Adora and continuing on down the hall.

"Walk with me," she commands. Adora hesitates, but Shadow Weaver doesn't slow down, so Adora is forced to hurry forward to catch up, hovering just behind her shoulder. She quickly realizes that they are on their way to the skiff yard. When they reach the entrance, Shadow Weaver draws to a halt. Adora brings herself up short, waiting as Shadow Weaver stares out into the yard.

"Hordak sees potential in you as a Force Captain, Adora – but I have always seen potential in you for much, much more," Shadow Weaver tells her, turning to look down at her. Adora's heart feels like it is buzzing against the backing of the Force Captain badge on her jacket, her entire body perking up at those words. It is an odd sensation after the last few moments of panicking about getting in trouble. Shadow Weaver isn't mad at her. She sees *potential* in her.

"It seems that the time has come for that potential to be unlocked. We will follow this voice. This sword may be the very weapon that we have been looking for," Shadow Weaver tells her, straightening up. Adora blows out a relieved breath. She isn't in trouble, Shadow Weaver hasn't even questioned her about Catra's

role in this, and she is finally going to find out why the thing is calling to her like this.

“Do you know about it?” Adora asks, a bit breathlessly, as Shadow Weaver glides forward into the yard. She swears her hair, ever alive and moving, takes on a satisfied curl. She is probably just projecting.

“Perhaps. Your description applies to many swords, Adora. We will have to see if this is the right one. Show me where you found it,” Shadow Weaver orders. Adora hurries forward.

“Yes, Shadow Weaver,” she agrees, eagerly. For the first time, the pull in her mind eases, as if quieted with the knowledge that she is on her way. She hopes this is the right sword, whatever that means. She hopes it is there again when they reach it. She doesn’t want to disappoint Shadow Weaver.

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If she hadn’t been worried about being caught, Catra would have chased after Adora immediately. Bad things happen when they are separated. Either the other cadets try to mess with Catra or Shadow Weaver finds one of them. Catra is lucky when she doesn’t walk away with a new nightmare, but it’s worse when she corners Adora instead. Catra feels like she loses a little bit more of her every time Shadow Weaver takes her off alone. She usually comes back more determined to advance, throwing herself into training and spending less time with Catra.

And then there is shit like Adora getting promoted and Catra being stuck as cadet. Catra never really wanted to be a Force Captain the same way that Adora did, but she does want to be assigned alongside her. She wants to be respected. She doesn’t want to be treated like the punching bag that she always has been despite performing as well as Adora does and sometimes better. Becoming

a Force Captain would give her security that she doesn't have now. Shadow Weaver would likely never let up, but she at least wouldn't be bothered by cadets anymore.

The Horde constantly pits everyone again each other, striving for improvement through competition, but you don't challenge a superior officer. Catra got so excited when she saw Adora's badge only to have her heart crushed a few moments later. She knew Shadow Weaver wouldn't promote her as willingly as she would Adora, but she thought their squad would be greenlit for active duty with her. They could get out into the world, Catra would at least be a step up from where she was before, and she and Adora would get time together on missions.

If she managed to get out in the field, maybe she could prove herself to Hordak. He doesn't have a personal vendetta against her and supersedes Shadow Weaver. Instead, Catra is being *left behind*. She tries to go back to bed, curling up in Adora's usual spot and pulling the blanket over her head so it looks like Adora is still sleeping there, but the thought of Adora leading a squad without her tomorrow has her claws flexing out. She fists the mattress, trying to control the angry betrayal in her chest, but after a moment she feels the fabric rip beneath her hands.

Fuck. She releases it, growling a little with frustration. She can't believe that Adora is leaving her behind. On the way back from the Whispering Woods, she assured Catra that she could talk Shadow Weaver into greenlighting the entire squad for duty if she just does well during the raid on Thaymor, but now here she is, sneaking off alone and telling Catra to stay behind. It doesn't seem like she is nearly as worried about them being separated. Has Shadow Weaver finally gotten to her?

Catra barely tamps down her growl as she pushes the blanket off her head. She hisses when the static built up from it rubbing her hair zaps her ear, though she manages to keep her tones low. No one stirs as she kicks the blanket away and sits up. She can't keep lying here. She can't do *nothing*. She knows where Adora is going. Better that she just goes and gets Adora now. She doesn't want to

be left behind, and it isn't like Shadow Weaver would believe any cover story that she spins anyway.

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Adora slows the skiff to a halt just within the edge of the Whispering Woods, glancing at Shadow Weaver nervously. She expects to be yelled at for being reckless enough to enter the Whispering Woods on her own, but instead Shadow Weaver is looking up at the treetops, seeming oddly awestruck. Not that their incredible height isn't impressive, but Shadow Weaver is never *awed*.

"Of course…" she breathes, seemingly to herself. Shadow Weaver is rarely so surprised that she thinks aloud, but she is clearly having a revelation. Adora just counts herself lucky that Shadow Weaver is too preoccupied to remember that Adora came here – supposedly alone – earlier in the day. She carefully eases the skiff down to the ground when the undergrowth grows thick. They could fly over it, but the plants would obscure the sword from view.

"What is it?" she asks, quietly. The Woods are even creepier at night. There are small flickers of light from glow bugs as they step off the skiff, forms of life foreign to the Fright Zone, though she has heard of them. The night breeze causes the foliage to stir, making it impossible to tell if anyone is approaching or *surrounding* them. No wonder their squadrons don't come back. An ambush would be easy here, especially for rebels familiar with the territory. Shadow Weaver halts, turning to Adora and reaching down to place a hand on her shoulder.

"Your *destiny*, Adora. The sword's location will be obscured by the Woods' magic, but if it is truly meant for you, it will call to you. Follow that pull. With this sword, you could become our greatest

asset against the Rebellion," Shadow Weaver commands her. Adora feels her heart pick up, her face setting with determination as she nods. She salutes for good measure.

"I won't let you down," she promises. Shadow Weaver pulls back, seeming pleased. Adora turns to the dark mass of the forest, her determination only slightly dimmed by the intimidating gnarl of trees. If this sword is so important that it could single-handedly turn the tide, it is worth the risk. She doesn't usually try to focus on her feelings, so it is hard to turn inward and follow some invisible pull, but now that she is back in the woods, she can feel a buzz in her veins. It is unnerving, but she tells herself it is a good sign.

Shadow Weaver's interest in the sword is assuring to her. She isn't having a breakdown. Her strange dream was… something. A part of something *important*. She forges through the undergrowth, only pausing when Shadow Weaver starts to lag behind. She has been within the manufactured hallways of the Fright Zone for a long time and isn't dressed for climbing over giant tree roots regardless.

The Woods are intimidating. Adora is worried about getting them lost. The undergrowth seems to be growing thicker as they walk. She can't help but worry that they won't be able to make their way out again. If she gets Shadow Weaver stranded in the woods, she is going to be demoted at *best*. Her anxiety is building again, her chest feeling like an echo chamber as her heartbeat hammers through it too fast to be healthy. She is just about to open her mouth and suggest they turn back when Shadow Weaver draws in a startled breath.

Adora whips around to find her facing to the side, towards a glow suddenly crowning the bushes. Oh. That's why her heart was hammering. It's the exact same glow that beckoned her towards the sword the first time. Adora quickly barrels forward through the bushes. She knows this must be it, but she has to go on ahead regardless. She can't lead her superior officer into danger. She fights her way through the thick growth around the clearing,

drawing to a halt when she sees the sword again. It is still buried in the ground, vines wrapping around it and the shine emanating from the blue gem in its hilt.

Adora swallows as she hears Shadow Weaver fighting her way through the small path that she made. She knows that she should help her, but she feels drawn in by the sword, walking slowly forward until she is within distance to grab it. She is a little nervous to touch it again. Last time she passed out and woke up in a different clearing. She knows the Whispering Woods move – that is why they have never been able to penetrate it, their squadrons quickly getting split up by the shifting landscape – but she wants someone to watch her this time to make sure that she doesn't lose the sword again.

"Adora," Shadow Weaver calls from behind her. Adora manages to look back to glance over her shoulder. Shadow Weaver is standing near the edge of the clearing, almost like she doesn't want to approach the light. Shadow Weaver inclines her head to the sword.

"That is the Sword of Protection, an ancient magic relic. If you wield it in the name of the Horde, we will finally have the strength to crush the Rebellion," Shadow Weaver tells her. Adora rarely hears her this worked up, but she sounds excited, like she is already making battle plans in her head. Adora swallows, turning back to the sword. She wants to make a difference for the Horde. If the sword is that powerful, then it could finally be her shot at making all her and Catra's dreams come true.

"Is it dangerous? The last time I touched it, I passed out," Adora asks. The gem on the hilt seems to gleam before her. She swears her heart stutters. Is it a beckon, or a warning?

"The sword will not harm you. With its runestone, you can use the same magic that the Princesses abuse against them. You can free Etheria from their tyranny. Take it, Adora. Become the Princess of the Horde that I raised you to be," Shadow Weaver commands her. Adora's heart hammers as she reaches out. The idea of using

princess magic is scary, but if she starts going out of control like the Princesses, she can just drop the sword, right? Catra would be able to take it from her. She wouldn't let Adora fly off the handle. Besides, the sword is *cool* and Adora wants it.

Just as her hand touches the handle, she hears voices. They definitely aren't Shadow Weaver, but it's too late. She isn't in the Whispering Woods anymore. Crystalline shapes rise around her, replacing the grass of the forest with blues and purples, strange writing scrawled across them. Before her, a strange woman stands in a glowing doorway. Adora was prepared for something to happen based off her last experience, but she wasn't expecting this. The sounds of the forest have disappeared, a silent void surrounding her as she stares at a towering woman.

"Hello, Adora," the woman greets, her voice oddly tinny and robotic. It is the same one that Adora has been hearing ever since she first saw the sword.

"What's going on? What is this?" she asks, her voice coming out a lot more unsure than she wants it to. She can't help it. This whole thing is *weird*. Looking side to side, she finds nothing but crystalline structures and blackness. The woman seems entirely emotionless as she stares down at her.

"My name is Light Hope. I have been waiting for you for a long time, but I could not reach you until you forged your connection with the sword. Etheria has need of you, Adora. Will you answer its call? Will you fight for the honor of Grayskull?" Light Hope asks, a projection of the sword flickering to life before Adora. Adora swallows, reaching out for it and watching her hand pass right through it.

"What's Grayskull? What is going on with the sword? I don't know what any of this is," Adora asks, her tone pleading. If this woman can call out to her in her dreams, she must know something, but she is being just as cryptic as Shadow Weaver was. Suddenly, the world flickers, jolting and throwing Adora off balance. The projection of the sword vanishes and for a moment there is

nothing in the doorway but blackness. As Adora struggles back to her feet on the tilted floor, her heart pounding, the glowing white light flickers back to life. Light Hope's outline casts a long shadow in its center.

"We don't have much time," she says, her voice still robotic, but with a desperate tinge to it. As Adora opens her mouth, about to ask what is happening, she hears a distant yell. It's that voice from right before the Woods disappeared. Whoever they are, they are breaking in. Adora can hear the sounds of fighting around her now, the sound distant and yet so close, but there remains nothing except the crystalline structures.

"Adora, Etheria needs She-ra. You must balance the planet. Will you fight for the honor of Grayskull?" Light Hope asks, the final words seeming to reverberate around her until all she can hear is *for the honor of Grayskull* surrounding her, echoing against her eardrums. The sword flickers into existence before Adora again, this time higher in the air and seeming more solid. Adora swallows. She knows that she is meant to take it, but Shadow Weaver didn't mention anything about Grayskull. She doesn't know if she is making some kind of deal that she will come to regret.

"*Rrah!*" Catra's voice echoes in her ears, an effort in the midst of the battle. Adora whips around, but there is no one there. She doesn't know how Catra got here – and also *not* here – but she sounds like she is in trouble. She is fighting someone. She *needs* Adora's help. Adora turns back to the sword, her face set with determination. She reaches forward. This time, the sword handle is firm beneath her hand when she grasps it, warm like her hand was always meant to be wrapped around it.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" she cries, hoisting it aloft.

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Catra had to steal a different skiff – the set of keys that Adora used earlier were already gone – but she knew where to take it to look for Adora. At least, she did until she reached the edge of the Whispering Woods, but she quickly found Adora's abandoned skiff and was able to follow her trail through the undergrowth. She picked up on Shadow Weaver's presence before she heard her voice up ahead. It was a cry of exertion and it terrified her. Shadow Weaver catching Adora is bad news, but Shadow Weaver exerting herself is *worse*.

Catra climbs a tree for a better vantage point, and that is when she hears the fighting. She doesn't need to follow a trail now. She leaps between the tree branches just like she does in the simulations, following the sounds of… magic? It must be. Shadow Weaver is fighting someone, two other voices calling to each other. Catra slows as she sees a clearing up ahead, carefully leaping so the trunk mostly obscures her and peering around it.

The scene below is chaos. Shadow Weaver stands near the edge of the clearing, shadows gathered around her for protection. An archer is lurking in the bushes on the far side of the clearing, trying to shoot at her, but the arrows aren't penetrating her shadow barrier. Catra has a lot of experience with Shadow Weaver's shade magic, though, and she can tell it is growing *weak*. The shining light from the center of the clearing isn't helping, nor is the ring of shadows she is trying to maintain around it, encircling Adora as she slumps over a glowing sword, unconscious.

A princess, purple and sparkly, keeps trying to teleport within range of either Adora or Shadow Weaver, but every time she gets near the shadows, they lash at her. Catra stares down at Adora, kneeling with both hands wrapped around the handle despite how she is slumped against it. Her earlier mumbling about a sword wasn't a hallucination, then, but Catra doesn't know what the princess – or Shadow Weaver – did to her to make her lose consciousness like this. She doesn't know why Adora came out

here at all if Shadow Weaver caught her sneaking out, but the fight seems on the verge of being lost.

Just as she thinks that, Shadow Weaver's shield flickers at the exact wrong moment. One of the arrows slips through the gap and hits her in the shoulder. Shadow Weaver cries out and all the shadows in the clearing blink out of existence as she falls back, seemingly lifeless. Adora is left defenseless as Shadow Weaver collapses and doesn't so much as groan in pain.

"Oh, shoot," the archer cringes at the same moment that the princess throws her firsts in the air and cheers. He stands up, hurrying forward towards Shadow Weaver as if *concerned*. The princess doesn't pretend to care about the enemy. She turns towards Adora. Her magic has a sound, sparkles made audible, and Catra hears it gathering as she prepares to teleport to Adora now that she is vulnerable. Catra isn't about to let that happen. Whatever is wrong with Adora, she has to get her out of this. Shadow Weaver she could take or leave.

She leaps from the trees, bellowing as she goes to disrupt Sparkles' concentration. It works. The princess startles, the magic glow around her dropping as she whips around and gets just long enough to make eye contact with Catra before her fist comes down hard on her face, aided by the force of the drop. They roll, Catra springing back up on her feet, but the princess doesn't get up, lying on the ground and groaning as she reaches for her head.

"One good hit? That's really all it takes with you princesses?" Catra snarks as the archer looks up, his expression aghast. It was a *good* hit, but Catra has kept fighting through worse.

"Glimmer!" he shrieks, abandoning his inspection of Shadow Weaver's wound to reach back into his quiver. The first arrow Catra dodges, leaping to the side and putting herself between Adora and the threat. On the ground, the princess – Sparkles, Glimmer, whatever – pushes herself up onto her forearms and then *vanishes*, teleporting out of sight. Catra doesn't like the idea

of an enemy that can appear from nowhere, but at least she knows that she is fragile.

The second arrow Catra swipes out of the air. She can't dodge it, it would just hit Adora. In front of Catra, a shower of sparkles suddenly bursts into life with Glimmer in its center, her fist pulled back to hit Catra back. Catra recoils, preparing for the hit. With a wind-up like this, it is going to hit hard, and dodging so she hits Adora instead isn't an option she is willing to take when she doesn't know what is wrong with her.

The hit doesn't come.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" Adora suddenly yells from behind her. Instantly, the glow at her back flares and hits her like a physical wave, knocking her off her feet and blasting the princess backwards. Catra scrabbles as she is thrown forward. She doesn't manage to land on her feet, but she rolls and springs up, turning to face this new threat.

It isn't a threat. She gapes at the spot where Adora once stood. Adora is still there, but she is… glowing. And eight feet tall. And wearing a tiara. Her hair, suddenly massive, flows in a non-existent wind along with her cape and skirt as she slowly turns towards the center of the clearing, surveying it. Her expression is oddly blank, her eyes roving over the scene before her almost sightlessly. Catra's fur is bristling, awe and fear mixing beneath her skin. How the hell did this happen? Is Adora still in there somewhere?

Adora suddenly raises her arm, holding the sword she was hunched over out in front of her and showing Catra the flat of the blade. The gem begins to glow, giving Catra just enough warning to squeak and drop to the ground before a blast fires out from it. Glimmer cries out as it connects. Catra turns her head in just enough time to see her go flying into the bushes at the edge of the clearing, the blast having knocked her back as she tried to charge them. Catra swallows, looking up at the princess standing in Adora's place with her ears plastered back against her head.

“Adora? Adora, we need to get out of here,” Catra tries, already tensing her body to prepare to flip away should the words cause her to attack. Adora turns her head, looking down at her with no recognition. Catra swallows, fisting her hands at her sides. Suddenly, Adora moves, sweeping forward before Catra can react. She finds herself lifted into the air and thrown over her shoulder, scrambling for purchase with her claws, but Adora doesn’t halt. She moves at inhuman speed, Shadow Weaver suddenly flung over her opposite shoulder to join Catra.

Adora charges through the trees with one of them over each shoulder. Catra manages to get her legs wrapped around her, though it is hard given how wide her torso is now. It gives her enough leverage to lift her head and look behind her, in the direction they are charging. Adora is charging through the undergrowth like a bull, swinging the sword in front of her to cut them a path. She moves it with a precision that should only come after extensive training with a weapon, but whoever this is, she doesn’t have Adora’s knowledge.

Just her face. At least she listened to Catra. She hopes so, anyway. She has no idea where they are going. They could be headed further into the woods for all she knows. It is a relief when they burst into the clearing at the edge of the woods where they parked their skiffs. Suddenly, Adora draws to a complete halt, but she doesn’t put Catra down. She just stops as if deactivating now that her task is done.

“On the skiff, Adora,” Catra tries. Her heartrate hasn’t slowed down, but the words seem to work. Adora starts forward again, approaching the edge of the skiff and then sliding Shadow Weaver off her shoulder to drop her on its floor. Catra winces as Shadow Weaver groans with pain, though she seems to have been unconscious ever since her magic failed. She squeaks as she suddenly feels too-large hands on her own waist. She quickly releases Adora, blinking up at her as she places Catra on the skiff floor as well and then climbs aboard herself. Her expression is still blank.

Catra swallows. Okay, at least Adora still seems to remember her enough to follow her orders in whatever state this is. What *happened* to her, some kind of princess curse that backfired? Maybe she was meant to attack her companions. It seemed like she was going to hit Catra for a moment at the beginning there. Before Catra can open her mouth to ask questions, her ear twitches. She can hear blundering in the woods. The rebels are following them. Adora did leave a very obvious path behind.

Catra cautiously climbs to her feet, but though Adora watches her, she doesn't seem to be suddenly provoked by the movement. Catra hurries to the keel, quickly taking command of the skiff. Adora watches blankly as Catra turns the key and lifts the skiff off the ground, but as she begins to pilot them out of the woods, the glow emanating from Adora suddenly flickers. She drops to one knee, her hair falling to plaster against her the final warning before there is a flash and suddenly the tall warrior is gone, leaving just Adora in her place.

"Adora!" Catra calls, unable to leave the keel to reach for her as she steers them out of the woods. She can still hear the rebels and needs to prioritize getting them *out* of here. Adora squints at her for a moment, recognition in her eyes even as she sways in her kneeled position. A moment later, her eyes close and she collapses to the floor of the skiff, joining Shadow Weaver in the unconscious pile. She looks uninjured despite her collapse. Catra just has to get them back to the Fright Zone to get help.

Then she can find out what happened here.

Chapter End Notes

> This AU diverges from canon at episode one, so all of my pre-canon Outside of the War fics are still canon to this universe, but there are… *some things* in the backstory of this AU <.< that I don't consider canon to that series/the show. This AU is all my "what ifs". Well, not all of them ;)
> This first fic corresponds to the opening episode where it diverges from, but I won't be following the show from here

on out as many things would change based off the early events.

Part II

Chapter Notes

> If you haven't read my fics before, Catra is feline (red) colorblind. This fic explores it and is canon to this series up until it reaches the show itself. I told y'all that Outside of the War was canon to this.
> The series title is from this AU's theme song, Alpha by Little Destroyer. *Mister Preacher, time to give up the throne // I'm master now, damn it's good to be home.*

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The rebels don't try to follow them. Catra looked back and saw them climbing onto the skiff that was left behind, but that was Catra's skiff, and she still has the key hanging on her belt. They can't follow them in it. She manages to take off into the desert, Adora and Shadow Weaver still unconscious on the floor. She breathes easier when she is out of sight of the woods, but she never slows down. She needs to get them both help as fast as possible. She has a feeling that only Shadow Weaver can explain what happened back there fully and she is currently bleeding.

Adora starts stirring when the Fright Zone is finally within eyeshot again. Catra has never been more relieved in her life than when Adora groans, rolls over, and blinks her eyes open at the sky. Her gaze is distant, but after a moment she manages to prop herself up and squint back at Catra, still manning the keel. She wants to run forward and get her hands on Adora, checking that she is alive and well beneath with her touch, but getting back has to be the priority, so she keeps steering them reluctantly.

"What happened?" Adora asks, her voice a bit raw. Catra glances down to send her an incredulous look.

"Don't ask me, I only showed up in time to save your asses! You're the one who started *glowing*!" she shoots back. She tries to

push the skiff harder, but it is already maxed out – and low on fuel. They are almost to the edge of the Fright Zone, though. They have enough left to get within range of help. Adora grimaces, looking down at herself. She seems to notice the sword, still in her hand, for the first time since waking. She lifts it, staring down into the gem on the hilt like it is suddenly going to start talking to her.

"Why the hell was Shadow Weaver there, and what is that thing?" Catra demands as she cruises them over a low outer wall. Before the Rebellion was forced to withdraw to the trees, these walls used to be manned as a defensive perimeter, but now they just mark the edges of where cadets are allowed to roam. Catra's words seem to remind Adora of Shadow Weaver's existence. Her head pops up and she whips around, looking wildly for her until she spots her laid out at the end of the skiff, right where she left her. Who knows if Adora even remembers what happened when she was transformed by magic, though.

Catra is wary of the sword still in her hand, but even if she were okay with briefly touching it herself, she hasn't paused long enough to kick it away from her. She hasn't even looked at Shadow Weaver's shoulder. It isn't bleeding much, so it can wait. Tending to it won't do any good if the rebels catch them. Besides, Catra knows the same basic first aid that all cadets are taught, but it isn't her specialty. Adora scrabbles to the end of the skiff and sits cross-legged, resting the sword in her lap so she can inspect the injury with both hands. At least another glowing princess doesn't immediately spring out of the blade when she releases it.

"She found out about the stolen key earlier and was waiting for me when I snuck out again. I had to admit where I was going. When I told her about the sword, she knew what it was, but she wouldn't tell me much. She had me take her to where I saw it. It… makes me magic, I guess. I don't know, I need Shadow Weaver to explain more," Adora calls over her shoulder as she inspects the wound. Catra focuses her eyes forward as the skiff yard looms before them. She brings them in slowly, grateful it is

still the early hours of the morning. There aren't a lot of people around, but there is someone who can help.

"Hey, you! Get over here!" Catra shouts, putting as much authority into her voice as she can as she points across the yard to the scorpioni idling near its entrance. She is probably waiting for somebody to come back or has been placed on guard duty after two skiffs went missing, but Catra doesn't care why she is there. She has broad shoulders and looks like she can carry Shadow Weaver without aggravating her wound.

The woman turns around and immediately starts hurrying their way. If she gets offended about a cadet yelling at her once she gets close enough to see Catra's badge, she can just lean on Adora's Force Captain credentials and the obvious *emergency* on hand. The woman draws to a halt at the edge of the skiff, gasping with horror when she spots Adora tending to Shadow Weaver. Shadow Weaver isn't even visibly bloody – though her dark robes would make it hard to tell – but the arrow sticking out of her chest is a bit of a shocking sight.

"We got ambushed by rebels. Shadow Weaver needs immediate medical attention. Take her to the infirmary," Catra orders, her voice hard despite how she has spotted the woman's Force Captain badge now and knows she is in no position to give her instructions. Faking authority seems to work though, because the woman immediately salutes to her and climbs over the skiff's railing.

"Right away, sir!" she agrees without hesitation. Catra isn't used to being called sir. Her tail twitches as Adora scoots back to give the Force Captain room to pick up Shadow Weaver and lift her bridal style between her pincers. Catra likes it, but she doesn't have that authority. If this wasn't an emergency, the Force Captain would have realized who was giving her orders by now, but she isn't looking at Catra's badge as she carefully adjusts Shadow Weaver in her arms and then hops off the skiff.

Adora starts to go after her, but Catra darts forward and grabs her shoulder once the woman's back is turned. Adora hesitates, looking back to her. She still has the sword in her hand. The Force Captain is flat out sprinting now that she is on the ground. She will get Shadow Weaver to medical attention and she will be fine. Before she wakes up, though, they need to get their story straight.

"Adora, I need you to tell me everything," Catra tells her. Adora cringes a little, but she nods.

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They go up to their platform. As they walked through the halls trying to find somewhere private to talk, they started drawing attention from the soldiers waking up for the day. Adora doesn't know if the Force Captain – Adora has seen her once or twice in Force Captain line-ups and thinks her name is Scorpia – shouted what happened to everybody she passed, but the fact that Adora is still carrying the sword doesn't help. Its gemstone almost seems to glow in the dim halls of the Fright Zone. They need privacy to talk and they aren't going to get that with everyone looking at them. There is no one to overhear them up on their platform.

Catra sits on the railing, her back to the view as she looks at Adora, standing a few feet away and fidgeting with the sword. She is a little nervous about trying to put it down. She doesn't think it will do anything unless she says that phrase again – it seems to be a passcode – but after everything they went through to recover it, she doesn't want someone else to take it. It isn't uncommon for the best piece of equipment – the one staff that doesn't stick when it extends, the most comfortable piece of armor, or the non-regulation blade that someone found on a raid – to constantly change hands as people swipe things from each other.

Catra has Adora walk her through every moment of the last day, from Adora seeing the sword for the first time when she fell from the skiff to getting caught by Shadow Weaver and leading her out into the Woods. Explaining the vision she had upon touching it is hard, especially because she doesn't know what happened while she was having it really, though between the two of them they can fill in the gaps. Catra tells her about what she came upon while Adora was having her weird vision. As Adora describes waking up again, Catra eyes the sword in her hand warily.

"Are you sure it's safe?" she asks. Adora blows out a slow breath, turning the blade over in her hand until she can see her reflection in it. She looks like shit, her half grown out bangs fallen out of her ponytail and dust from the drive through the wasteland caked on her skin and hair. As she looks down into the blade, she swears she sees her eyes flash an unnatural blue. Catra's fur bristles in her periphery. Okay, so that definitely happened.

"Yeah, I'm sure. It didn't feel totally in control, but I just knew that you were in danger and I had to protect you. I was mostly acting on instinct," Adora admits. She doesn't really know for sure that it is safe, but it didn't feel dangerous. She isn't worried about the sword hurting anyone and she doesn't want Catra to be either. It didn't feel like being overtaken or replaced. She just felt power pulsing through her. Catra's ears pin back and she scowls, her concern momentarily forgotten. She turns her head away, crossing her arms and sulking back against the railing.

"Excuse me, I was protecting *you* while you were *un-fucking-conscious*. You almost shot me, too," she huffs, her tail twitching with annoyance. She is practically pouting. It's kind of adorable, but Catra is right. Not about the shooting thing – Adora knew that Catra would understand her movements and dodge without Adora having to speak and tip off the princess attacking them – but Catra did help protect her while she was still waking up.

"You did. I didn't hear the rebels until I was already passing out and it was too late. They might have been waiting for us," she acknowledges, glancing down at the blade in her hand. If the

rebels knew that it was powerful and couldn't use it for themselves, it makes sense to stake it out. You would think they would leave a larger team, but even a single princess is a formidable enemy. Adora should know – she just became one and it felt *electrifying*.

"Hey! Catra! I know you're up there, I can see your tail!" Lonnie's voice comes calling from down below. Catra scowls, turning around to lean over the rail and glare down at the source of the interruption. Adora approaches it to look down with her, finding Lonnie two stories down and waving up to them.

"Hordak wants a debrief on how the hell you got Shadow Weaver shot!" Lonnie calls up. Adora cringes as Catra squeaks beside her, her tail lashing to wrap around her legs and her ears flattening back.

"We'll be right down!" Adora calls back despite how her own heart is beating quickly. She has seen Hordak many times, but usually only when he was addressing a large group that she happened to be a part of. He used to give speeches more regularly when they were growing up, but as the war has progressed, he has become more focused on working on their technology, trying to advance it past that of the Rebellion's. He is rarely seen these days. She has never had a one-on-one with him before. Well, one-on-two.

As they step back from the railing to cross to the other side where Adora's usual way down is, Catra waits only until they are out of Lonnie's eyesight to turn and fist the front of Adora's jacket. She gets close to the sword for the first time just to get up in Adora's face and make burning eye contact with her, urgency written across her features.

"We need to have our story straight before we meet him," she says. Adora flushes, nodding quickly. That's a good idea. She doesn't know why Catra needs to be so close to work it out, though. It's distracting. Luckily, Catra releases her once she nods. Adora starts breathing normally now that she doesn't have Catra exhaling in her face. The lack of oxygen was getting to her.

"Okay. What are we telling him?" she asks.

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Adora has to be the one to talk to Hordak. It should be Catra – she would be way better at it – but Adora is the Force Captain. Even they don't usually report directly to Hordak, but a cadet certainly can't get away with it when there is a Force Captain right there that could be asked instead. They can't lie much – they definitely can't contradict anything that Shadow Weaver will say once she recovers – but they can cover their asses about stealing the skiff in the first place.

Catra doesn't think that Shadow Weaver will tell Hordak about that even once she recovers. It would make her star pupil look bad. Standing at the base of the steps up to the throne is nerve-wracking, especially with Imp scurrying through the rafters and wires, chittering as machines move behind the throne. When Hordak steps out, he already has his eyes narrowed looking down on them. It's a bad sign for how receptive he is. Adora salutes and Catra follows suit. Hordak *hmphs* and comes to rest in his throne as he looks down at them.

"Force Captain Adora. This is not what I expected of your first mission. *Explain*," he commands. Catra's heartbeat feels like it is pounding through her entire body as Adora steps forward and kneels, holding up the sword with one hand still firmly wrapped around the handle and the other on the blade, presenting it lengthwise to Hordak.

"I spotted this sword near the edge of the Whispering Woods yesterday. When I told Shadow Weaver what I had seen, she was convinced that it was the Sword of Protection and that its abilities would be key in the war. She came with me to recover it, but a group of rebels attacked us. Shadow Weaver was injured in the

fight before we escaped," Adora says, launching into the explanation that they came up with on the roof.

It is mostly just a simplified version of what happened. The less they have to tell Hordak, the better. Catra's skin wants to crawl just standing here. If Shadow Weaver can be intimidating, Hordak is that times three. He isn't just their superior officer, he is the *ultimate* officer. His word on anything is final. If he doesn't like their explanation, who knows if he will order them thrown in a cell for failing to protect a superior officer. He looks down at the sword in Adora's hands, seeming unimpressed.

"And what is this *Sword of Protection*?" he asks in a sneering drawl. He sounds bored at best and suspicious at worst. Catra's tail twitches slightly behind her. It's probably a good thing that he doesn't sound concerned for Shadow Weaver – it means that he is less likely to punish them over her injury – but answering questions about the arrow in her chest would be easier than explaining what the hell happened to Adora back in that clearing. On her knee, Adora hesitates.

"She didn't have time to explain before the rebels attacked. It is bound to me, though. I believe its runestone has the same magic as the Princesses, but the sword will let me use it against them for the Horde," Adora replies. Catra is shocked that she doesn't spill her guts about the whole *transformation* thing, but considering that they don't really know what that was, it is a good idea to keep quiet about it. Hordak sniffs as he looks down at them. He doesn't seem impressed by the blade, but after a moment he raises his hand and waves it in a shooing motion, as if dismissing them.

"Take Shadow Weaver to the Black Garnet chamber and see if it revives her. Notify me from the comm there once she is up. I want her to make a full report immediately," he commands. Catra lets out a slow breath that she didn't realize she had been holding for the entire conversation as Adora quickly nods and awkwardly scrambles to her feet, the sword in hand.

"Yes, Lord Hordak. Right away," she agrees, bowing to him once before turning to leave. She makes eye contact with Catra as she walks back to where she lingered a few feet back. They both exchange a relieved look as they hurry to leave. That went better than Catra feared it would, mostly because it seems that Hordak doesn't give a shit about Shadow Weaver's injury. Then again, if it was some random Force Captain getting injured on a mission, Shadow Weaver wouldn't care either.

Shadow Weaver would probably be furious if she knew how little Hordak cares about her, though. It seems that she has an inflated sense of her own importance to those above her. Hordak didn't care about her any more than he likely would any other subordinate. The knowledge has Catra smirking as they head towards the infirmary. It almost distracts her from the people eyeing them and whispering as they pass.

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Shadow Weaver's shoulder has been patched up. The wound is small and mostly superficial. The arrow was caught in her robe and what actually caused her to pass out was probably exhausting her magic supply. Still, she looks like death when they reach the infirmary. The Force Captain's name *is* Scorpia, it turns out. She is still there and she happily agrees to carry Shadow Weaver, now on a stretcher, to the Black Garnet chamber, but she seems nervous around the runestone, gingerly setting Shadow Weaver near it and then quickly excusing herself.

Adora doesn't really blame her. There are very few cadets who haven't been on the receiving end of its power. It can be intimidating. Catra, despite having felt it many times, isn't afraid, at least not right now. She walks right up and unbuckles Shadow Weaver, shifting her to lean back against it. She quickly steps back and pauses, waiting to see if anything will happen. The runestone

just sits there, as lifeless as Shadow Weaver. Adora steps up to Catra's shoulder as she snorts with amusement.

"Come on, old witch. Do your thing. Suck the life out of it," Catra snarks. Adora elbows her, shooting her a warning look, but she can't hide the way that the corner of her own mouth is twisting up. Catra could never get away with being so disrespectful to Shadow Weaver's face, but just being in the presence of the Black Garnet doesn't seem to be enough to wake her. They have both seen Shadow Weaver recharge before and it didn't look like the Black Garnet was happy to give its energy. It isn't surprising that it remains dormant without being coerced into helping her.

Time for Plan B. Adora holds the sword out to Catra, watching her eye it dubiously. Adora rolls her eyes, reaching down for Catra's wrist and raising it so her palm is up. Catra could easily pull away, but she reluctantly holds still as Adora places the hilt in her hand. She doesn't wrap her fingers around Adora's own on the hilt, however, refusing to take its weight and let Adora hand it off to her despite how its touch hasn't immediately electrocuted her.

"I need my hands free to move her," Adora points out. Catra wrinkles up her face, glaring down at the sword's reflective blade.

"Are you *sure* this thing isn't going to turn me into a princess too? You looked dumb enough in the tiara for the both of us," Catra replies, but she reluctantly wraps her hand around Adora's. Adora lingers with their fingers intertwined for a moment, letting Catra see that nothing is happening, then slips her fingers out from beneath Catra's and leaves the sword in her hand. Catra holds still as she waits for something to happen, not even breathing despite her tail lashing behind her. Of course, nothing does.

"Light Hope said she had been waiting for me. I don't think it will do anything for anyone else. You're fine," Adora assures her. She feels confident of that, but Catra still looks dubious as Adora steps forward and bends to lift Shadow Weaver up. She carefully throws her good arm over her shoulders so she doesn't strain her injury as she picks up her. Her legs are dragging on the ground still, but

Adora's priority is the mask. That is the center of Shadow Weaver's power.

She shuffles up to the edge of the runestone slowly, trying to avoid bashing Shadow Weaver's face on the front of the gem. The sound of her forehead coming to rest against it is quiet, so she thinks she succeeds in being somewhat gentle. For a long moment, nothing happens. Adora is just about to suggest that they take her to her bunk and see if she naturally wakes up on her own, no matter how impatient Hordak is, when the runestone begins to glow slightly. Adora draws in a sharp breath.

A moment later, Shadow Weaver's arm around her twitches. She has been breathing shallowly this whole time, but she draws in a rattling breath and then her hand twitches, grasping for the runestone. Adora reaches up, guiding it to awkwardly press against the cool runestone with her arm still slung around her shoulders. The glow of the runestone brightens, a slight crackle in the air that causes the hair on Adora's arms to stand on end, and then Shadow Weaver gasps.

She flails a little, struggling to get to her feet. Adora quickly ducks away so she doesn't get hit as sparks begin to arc between her and the runestone. Shadow Weaver is lucid enough to lean against the runestone on her own now, so Adora retreats back to stand beside Catra. Catra's tail is lashing behind her and she eagerly shoves the sword back to Adora. Adora takes it as Shadow Weaver straightens up, her hands still on the runestone as she continues to draw energy from it.

Her breathing evens out as the glow dims again. Catra's tail settles down to mere twitching as the charge in the air dissipates. For several long moments, Shadow Weaver just stands there, her hair and robe rippling back to life. Eventually, she draws in a deep breath and pulls back. Adora watches her shoulders move as she steeples her fingers together in front of her before she turns around. She is impassive as always behind her mask, but she takes them both in slowly.

“Report,” is all she says. Adora winces a little as Catra’s ears pin back.

“Um, I had a vision when I touched the sword and didn’t see much, but Catra realized that I was gone and followed our trail. She didn’t reach us until after you used up your magic and passed out. We fought the rebels off when I woke back up. Hordak wants a full report. He wasn’t satisfied with how little I knew about the sword,” Adora explains. She does it poorly – she and Catra didn’t agree on a *plan* first – but Shadow Weaver’s attention is drawn to the sword as soon as Adora mentions it.

She glides forward from the runestone as if nothing happened and they never saw her desperately clutching at it, halting in front of Adora and looking down at the sword in her hand. Adora brings it forward in front of her, the tip pointing down to the ground as she tightly grips the hilt with one hand and fidgets a bit with the pommel with her other. In her hands, the sword is warm. It doesn’t feel like it is just her body heat reflecting back at her, but rather like it is humming with life beneath its surface.

“Tell me about the vision,” Shadow Weaver orders. Adora blinks at her, expecting other questions, but after a moment she recovers and launches into the explanation for the second time. At least Shadow Weaver is more likely to have answers than Catra.

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Adora recaps the vision in more detail than she gave earlier. Shadow Weaver is so interested in it that she doesn’t seem to have even registered the fact that Catra snuck out as well to follow them. Catra internally cursed when Adora mentioned that detail, but apparently Shadow Weavers has priorities above torturing her for once in her life.

“Light Hope just kept asking me to fight for the honor of Grayskull. When I said that phrase to the sword, I woke up and I just felt… powerful. My body was different too, but I didn’t really see how. I was just suddenly strong enough to carry both you and Catra to safety,” Adora finishes, still fiddling with the sword. Catra’s ears pin back when she repeats the phrase, but that golden wave of light doesn’t return. Catra swears the runestone on the hilt *glints*, but nothing else happens. Shadow Weaver turns her head to Catra, narrowing her eyes. Catra swallows. She swears that Shadow Weaver enchanted the eye slits of her mask to follow her movements just to be more intimidating.

“She was eight feet tall and *glowing*. She had this weird half-skirt outfit on suddenly. There was a tiara. Her hair was down for once,” Catra elaborates, shrugging a little like she is unbothered by Shadow Weaver’s gaze being focused so strongly on her. She could probably sketch it, but it is hard to describe her best friend just transforming into someone else. Shadow Weaver doesn’t seem pleased with her description. Her eyes only narrow further.

“What color was it?” she asks. Catra blinks at her. She has no idea why that *matters* and answering the question is risky for her, but she can’t just ignore it. She will have to stick to the parts that she is sure of.

“White outfit, gold armor. Her hair got lighter and longer. Her eyes were really blue,” Catra explains. The cape was dark, but she doesn’t say that it was grey. She doesn’t know for sure and Shadow Weaver has yet to realize that Catra’s color vision is limited. She would bet that the cape was actually red, but if she says the wrong color, it will be telling. Luckily, Shadow Weaver seems satisfied with that, straightening back up from where she was starting to *loom* a little of Catra. She faces Adora once more.

“Her name is She-ra. There are ancient legends of her, but they are more myth than history. You are the first person fit to embody her in hundreds of years, Adora. I always knew you had a great destiny before you. Wielding this sword in the name of the Horde is what I raised you for,” Shadow Weaver tells her, reaching a

hand out to place on her shoulder. The words set Catra's teeth on edge. It explains *too much* about how Shadow Weaver has always acted around Adora: things like her favoritism and why she took Adora – and thus Catra, by extension – on as a personal ward.

Neither of them were ever treated like a regular cadet, even if they trained alongside the rest of them. Adora was on the Force Captain track from too young of an age for her to have shown early promise. Catra always put it down to Shadow Weaver's personal ward needing to be successful if only for her own ego. She didn't get the same treatment because Shadow Weaver hated her, but this whole *She-ra* thing puts it in a new perspective. Catra doesn't buy into magical destiny bullshit, though.

"How? How did you know? She's just a *person*," Catra asks before she can help herself. She watches Shadow Weaver's hand by her side twitch to form a fist before she can fully get her anger under control. Shit. Catra still meets her eyes when Shadow Weaver turns her head to look at her. She has to. She has to challenge her, because Adora is looking up at Shadow Weaver with honest, innocent curiosity. She wants to know too, but she wouldn't have made such a rude demand of her superior officer.

"Her essence was unique. Unlike *some others*," Shadow Weaver sneers like Catra gives enough of a shit to even find that insulting. "The Princesses fight with magic. We must be able to match them. She-ra was unstoppable in battle and possessed magical abilities. With training, Adora, you will become powerful. She-ra is the key to finally defeating the rebellion," Shadow Weaver explains, turning back to Adora and promptly ignoring Catra. Catra fists her hands at her sides.

"And if it's dangerous? You didn't see her. It took her over," Catra shoots back, gesturing to the sword still in Adora's hands. Adora turns to her as if to speak, but she pauses when Shadow Weaver's hand on her shoulder spasms, her fingers digging into Adora from her annoyance. After a moment, Shadow Weaver manages to force herself to let go of Adora, pivoting to face Catra. Anger

radiates off her. Shit. Catra's tail lashes as the shadows around Shadow Weaver begin to reach up, feeding off her anger greedily

"And why were you there, Catra? Skiffs don't leave a trail. You *knew* where we were. Did you drag Adora to the woods earlier? Try to convince her to abandon her duties for you?" Shadow Weaver demands, disdain dripping from her voice as she advances on Catra. Catra takes a reflexive step back as that *charge* fills the air again. This is somewhere she has been many times before. Adora steps forward, reaching out to Shadow Weaver, though even she doesn't dare touch her, her hand hovering in the air.

"No, it was my idea. I wanted to celebrate the promotion," Adora tells her, her tone a bit pleading. Shadow Weaver hardly seems deterred, glancing down to Adora for only a moment.

"I know you wouldn't have tried something like this without her *influence*. You are She-ra, Adora. You are above these childish games. If you cannot keep her in line, how will you ever lead the Horde to victory?" Shadow Weaver snaps. Adora recoils as if burned, her expression distraught. For a moment, she fails to find words, and in that moment Shadow Weaver turns back to Catra. Catra's tail lashes behind her. Adora should fucking *defend* her, but Catra will do it her damn self if she won't. She doesn't need help.

"Adora stole the keys without even telling me. She drove the skiff herself. She snuck out again *without* me. You're blind if you think this was my fault," Catra shoots back, gesturing angrily to Adora. Her claws are out. She is sick of being blamed when her *disobedience* led to her following them and probably saving their lives. Shadow Weaver's hair and robe lash violently, her shadow growing longer to loom over Catra. It is a warning that she has gone too far. She should back down.

She doesn't.

"Adora isn't the perfect puppet you want her to be. Every time after the first, she is the one who ki-" Catra starts to say, a small spark of victory lighting in her heart at the way that Shadow

Weaver recoils from the words. She is too weak from draining all her power to play her usual ace right now, which is probably why the shadows suddenly flare to life around her and she cuts Catra off with a roar, the word echoing in the shadows that encircle Catra.

"*Silence!* Adora's destiny is far beyond you and your *insolence*. You have tried to interfere with her destiny too many times. If I ever catch you trying to distract her from her purpose again, you will *wish* for your previous punishments in place of what I will inflict upon you," Shadow Weaver threatens, the shadows whipping around Catra in a circle, cutting off her view of the rest of the room. Catra's heart hammers as she flinches back.

She can't see anything in the darkness, not even Adora standing just a few feet away. Tendrils of smoky black surround her. Her body has already gone numb anticipating the strike. She knows this moment well – it is the same moment that has played out every time that they kissed, after all. Shadow Weaver's temper will flare and she will steal Adora's memory, locking Catra away in isolation without food for a few days, only releasing her when Catra swears that she will never touch Adora again.

She shouldn't have the power to do that right now. At least, Catra hopes not, but that is why she is doing her best to smother Catra in fear before Adora catches on to what she was saying. Catra feels a tendril of shadow wrap around her legs and hisses, instinctually leaping towards where Adora was last standing – towards *safety* – to escape it. Shadow Weaver's shade magic can manipulate space somewhat, but she must have just surrounded Catra in shadow, because she breaks through the wall easily and finds herself stumbling right into Adora.

It is still dark in the room in the rest of the room. Shadow Weaver whips around to face her, clearly incensed. Catra feels an arm wrap around her and looks up to find Adora's eyes glowing that inhuman blue again. Shadow Weaver hisses, recoiling a little in her periphery. Adora's arm tightens around Catra, suddenly unnaturally solid against her. Catra's breath hitches as Adora's

eyes beam through the darkness. The shadows seem to recoil from her, the brightness too much of them to take.

Adora notices the shadows retreating from her as well, her expression shifting from anxiety to determination. She raises her free arm with purpose, holding the sword aloft about her head.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" she declares. A wash of golden light sweeps over her body, transforming her and bathing the room in light. Like the dawn breaking on fast forward, the shadows in the room dissipate in the face of the shining golden light. It isn't as peaceful as the dawn, though; Shadow Weaver cries out like she is physically pained by her magic being dispelled, stumbling back as her breathing turns heavy and rattling. Catra finds herself pressed up against She-ra for the second time today, at least for a moment.

Panic spikes in her at the vice-like trap of muscle wrapping around her. She wriggles and Adora releases her, her face turning down to look at her with that same impassive expression from earlier. Freed and no longer in imminent danger, Catra is finally able to breathe again. She swallows, staring up at Adora for a moment before glancing around the room. The only shadows to be found are those naturally cast by the objects in the room as Adora beams light out like a signal flare. Shadow Weaver hunches on the floor, holding her head and panting. Anger is still radiating off her.

Suddenly, Shadow Weaver's head snaps up and she narrows her eyes at them. Catra flinches back despite her best efforts, but it just puts her in Adora's arms again, closer to the source of the light that Shadow Weaver's dark magic apparently can't touch. The thought emboldens her as she stares down at the face of the woman who has terrorized her all her life. Despite what Shadow Weaver says about her laziness, Catra has tried to prove herself before, but nothing she does is ever good enough for her.

Whenever Catra tries to take a small piece of happiness for herself – *Adora* – Shadow Weaver takes it from her. She is trying to do it now and she will try to do it again in the future. What is the

endgame here? Adora has dispelled the shadows, but what happens the next time that Shadow Weaver gets them alone? She will likely wipe Adora's mind of this incident the second that she has the magic reserves to. After a disobedience like this, Catra wouldn't be shocked if Shadow Weaver finally followed through on her threat to wipe Catra from her mind completely.

Catra doesn't decide to move, she just sees Shadow Weaver's shadow begin to stir again and it is the last straw. Panic and *anger* strike her heart at the same time and she lunges forward, raising her claws and bringing them down in a heavy strike against Shadow Weaver's mask. Shadow Weaver falls backwards, twisting as she does so from the force of Catra's claws coming down at an angle. The mask cracks beneath her claws, but most importantly, the shard of garnet from its forehead tumbles out of its broken setting.

Breathing heavily, Catra bends down and snatches it up between two claws. It isn't hard to press them together and shatter it in her state of adrenaline-fueled anger. For a long moment, everything is silent except for heavy breathing from both Catra and Shadow Weaver. Shadow Weaver's hair and robe aren't moving. She is unconscious again. Catra feels paralyzed as her actions catch up with her and she stares down at Shadow Weaver's lifeless form beneath her.

She doesn't know what they were going to do if she didn't cut off her magic, but she certainly doesn't know what they are going to do now that she *has*. They just attacked a superior officer. That isn't forgiven lightly. Shadow Weaver can't wipe Adora's memory now, but she can ruin their lives as Hordak's Second even without access to the Black Garnet's magic. They will be lucky if they don't both get thrown in prison for this.

Behind her, there is a flash of golden light. She turns to find She-ra gone and Adora gaping at her.

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Adora didn't fully decide to bring out She-ra. She just saw the fear in Catra's eyes and knew she had to help her. When the shadows shied away from the glow, however, she knew what she had to do to dispel them and make sure Catra was safe. She didn't have a plan after that, but she wasn't going to actually attack Shadow Weaver. She doesn't know if her shock is what makes her revert or if it is just that the immediate danger has passed now that Shadow Weaver is unconscious, but the magic pulsing through her skin dissipates as she stares down in shock.

Catra looks up, her eyes wild with dawning horror as she makes eye contact with Adora. For a long moment, they just stare at each other. Catra looks back down, staring aghast at what she has done. Shadow Weaver's breath rattles through the room, but she doesn't so much as twitch at Catra's feet.

"Okay, I panicked," Catra defends, looking back up to make eye contact again.

"You attacked Shadow Weaver," Adora says, her voice sounding distant even to her own ears. Catra winces, edging a little away from Shadow Weaver.

"She was going to separate us," Catra argues, shooting Adora a pleading look. Adora swallows, looking back down at Shadow Weaver. She has an anger problem and often turns nasty, but sometimes she can be talked down. With the leverage of She-ra, Adora is sure that she would have been able to talk Shadow Weaver down. Maybe she could have even been talked into letting Catra join her on active duty eventually. Shadow Weaver has always called her a distraction, but both of them post better times when they are together. Surely she would have seen reason eventually. She is a strategist, after all.

"She is going to kill us," Adora returns, her voice higher than usual. She might have been able to be talked down before, but *now*? Catra does have a history with lashing out – it is common to have to defend yourself in the Horde, but most cadets don't make a name for themselves as children for clawing someone's eye – but there is no way that Shadow Weaver is going to let an attack on herself go. Adora doesn't even know how to control She-ra yet. These last two times, it just came over her when someone was in danger. That isn't much of a bargaining chip, especially not to forget a transgression like *this*.

"We need to hide the body," is Catra's solution to that. She doesn't sound any less panicked than Adora does and her solution certainly isn't *good*. Adora gapes at her.

"*The body?!"* she shrieks back. Catra's tail is lashing, her claws out as she gestures wildly towards where Shadow Weaver is collapsed.

"I don't know! She's going to kill us when she wakes up! We have to do something," Catra replies, turning to stare down at her again. Adora is pretty sure that she is right about that, but she doesn't think that hiding Shadow Weaver like she is a *dead body* is going to help. What happens when she wakes up? They both get sent to *Beast Island* probably, She-ra be damned. Adora opens her mouth, but she is cut off by the crackling of the screen on the far wall.

Catra probably can't see it from where she stands, her view blocked by the Black Garnet, but Adora stands ramrod straight as Hordak comes into view on the screen, Imp crouched on his shoulder. Hordak sends a glance around the room before his eyes return to Adora. Imp tilts his head almost curiously.

"Status report," he orders. Adora swallows, utterly *panicking*. Can he see Shadow Weaver on the floor from where he is? Probably not, it's behind the Black Garnet and the camera isn't aimed at the floor. She buys herself some time with a salute, but she can't come up with a lie or force herself to say the *truth*.

“Shadow Weaver’s injury is very minor, but she isn’t waking, sir. It seems like draining her magic reserves completely put her in a coma,” Catra says, stepping around the side of the Black Garnet and into sight. Her voice is shockingly steady, even if it hasn’t made it all the way to calm. Adora could kiss her. Catra is the most brilliant person she has ever met. The lie buys them time to figure out what to do. Hordak doesn’t seem suspicious. If anything, he looks *annoyed*.

“She would have died a long time ago without the Black Garnet,” he comments. Adora swallows. She always knew that Shadow Weaver needed its power, but she didn’t know it was that *bad*. Hordak glances between them. “She prioritized Force Captain Adora retrieving the sword above all else?” he asks. Adora is startled by the question, but she quickly nods.

“Yes, sir,” she agrees. She feels like she must be obviously shaken, but Hordak is dismissive as he looks down his nose at her and sniffs.

“Then she better have trained you sufficiently as her ward. The invasion of Thaymor needs to go off without a hitch. Force Captain Adora, you are in charge of Shadow Weaver’s duties until further notice. If she recovers, she will be reinstated. I expect you to be an apt replacement in the meantime. I want no pause in normal operations,” he orders her. Adora’s shock is the only thing that delays her from gaping at him before the screen cuts out. He doesn’t even wait long enough for her to say *yes, sir*.

For a moment, Adora just stares at the screen. When she eventually tears her eyes from it, she gapes at Catra instead, who stares back with just as much shock on her face. The room is silent except for Shadow Weaver’s heavy breathing from the floor. Adora knows an entire military operation can’t collapse because of one person, but she is shocked by what just happened.

“I’m Shadow Weaver?! I’m barely even a Force Captain!” Adora says, her voice high and strangled. She sounds like she is mock screaming, but at least she isn’t actually yelling. She is still

catching up with the events of the last few minutes, but she knows being overheard now would be *bad*.

"Adora, focus? We just lied to Hordak! We need to get rid of her before she wakes up and tells someone the truth!" Catra returns. Adora swallows, staring across at her. Coming clean isn't really an option at this point, but neither is that.

"What are you suggesting we do, lock her up?" Adora asks, her voice still tinged with hysteria. Catra's lashing tail stills behind her.

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Catra knows this cell well. It is isolated, down on the lower levels where people don't go unless they are prisoners themselves. She has been in this cell exactly three times. It is almost karma to sneak Shadow Weaver down to it on the stretcher and put her in the chains that loomed over Catra ominously from the wall. Her magic isn't a danger – she doesn't have much without her mask – but Catra wouldn't put it above her to lunge at one of them when they come down to bring her food.

"I can't believe we're doing this," Adora says, despite how they already had a whispered conversation about this up in the Black Garnet chamber. The instant Adora – rhetorically – suggested this, the hysterical, barely-contained screaming stopped and they began a heat discussion of whispers, but neither of them could come up with a better plan. Shadow Weaver might have killed them upon waking, and Catra argued that they were in a good position with Hordak making Adora her replacement. Adora argued that she didn't know how to be Second, but they need to keep their freedom and heads.

"We've got this. We'll work it out together. We can always come to interrogate her if we really need to know something," Catra says with confidence that she doesn't feel at all. Her hands are a bit

shaky with adrenaline. Shadow Weaver always kept this cell blocked off, so no one should stumble across her here. The risk of discovery is minimal, but the reality of what has happened is still catching up with her. She feels a weird mix of horror and elation. They are free of Shadow Weaver, but now they have to *replace* her, and they still don't know much about the sword or what the hell She-ra is.

"What do we do now?" Adora asks, staring down at where they have moved Shadow Weaver to rest on the small cot in the cell. They already talked about this up in the Black Garnet chamber, but Catra knows that Adora isn't asking about the plan. They just usurped their superior officer and the woman who raised them in the most fucked up way possible. It is a weird feeling. Twenty-four hours ago, they were both just cadets and had know idea that Adora could become magic.

"We need to focus on Thaymor right now. As long as that goes well, we can work everything else out after," Catra promises her, turning away from Shadow Weaver to face Adora instead. Seeing Shadow Weaver look so broken makes her feel too conflicted. Adora doesn't look away from the cot, swallowing thickly as she stares down at Shadow Weaver.

"This isn't right," she says, softly. The blood rushes into Catra's ears as she stares at her. She wants to yell. She wants to scream. She wants to tear her claws into the wall. They flex uselessly at her side, but she grits her teeth and holds *still*. Adora doesn't know. Or at least, not anymore. She doesn't remember and Catra knows that. She watched Shadow Weaver rip Adora's memories away too many times. Every time was traumatic.

"I've been in this cell multiple times Adora. I was *fifteen* the first time. That isn't right. This is fucking justice," Catra grits out, balling up her fists. Her emotional pendulum is now swinging firmly away from guilt. Shadow Weaver is just reaping what she sowed. She *deserves* this. Adora will be a better Second than she ever was. Adora will be the only one with the job officially, but Catra will help her. She will need it. Together, they will lead the

Horde. It is just like they always planned, even if the circumstances aren't what they expected.

Adora winces, looking up to make eye contact with Catra. She almost looks disbelieving, but after a moment of staring into the hard expression on Catra's face, her expression turns distraught. She knows that Catra isn't lying. The truth is fucking *upsetting*. Adora must have a few memories of Catra being locked up as punishment still, but she certainly never saw the cell before. It makes the reality sink in. Shadow Weaver probably gave her a bullshit explanation for whatever rule Catra had broken. She would let her out after a day or two, so Adora didn't have long to wonder, and Catra never talked about it. Catra sighs, turning her face away.

"Come on, we need to go review the invasion plans. We only have ten hours," Catra reminds her, stepping closer and bumping Adora's shoulder with her own, though she still doesn't make eye contact. She doesn't want to talk about this right now – or ever. Everything feels far too fragile and uncertain to try to tell Adora the truth about those visits when she has carried the secret for years. She did so under threat from Shadow Weaver, but no part of her is actually convinced that she is safe from her yet. They need to not be discovered for a bit before it will feel real.

Besides, now isn't the time to breach the conversation with Adora. She is also reeling from the fight with Shadow Weaver, not to mention the promotion and magic bullshit. She doesn't remember that they have kissed and Catra being presumptive about it now won't help. So far, Adora has consistently kissed her again months later, but it has been nine months since the last incident and Adora hasn't shown any signs of wanting to do it again. Catra has lost so much of Adora to Shadow Weaver and she has always been terrified that Shadow Weaver will be successful in cutting out the part of Adora's mind that somehow wants her whenever she takes her memories.

She hopes she didn't manage it last time, but she doesn't *know*. She will have to tell Adora about all of it eventually, but while they

are running on barely any sleep, processing something so big, and preparing to go into the field for the first time isn't the time. Adora hesitates for a long moment, but eventually she nods. Catra breathes out a sigh of relief as they both turn away from Shadow Weaver and leave the cell, blacking it out behind them so there is no risk of someone walking by and spotting Shadow Weaver.

The invasion has to come first. They can handle everything else one thing at a time afterwards.

Chapter End Notes

> Catra had a small PTSD snap back in the Black Garnet chamber, but she doesn't know what that is, so in her mind she was just pushed to her limit in that moment.
> Soooo I don't consider it canon that they ever kissed before the show, but that's one of the "what ifs" that I threw into this AU since it's divergent and such a heartbreaking headcannon. We all know how I love heartbreak. The difference in motivation and fear from that backstory detail is actually why Catra got up during the night to follow Adora in this verse.
> Next up: Bite The Hand That Feeds.

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